

Deer

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Artiodactyla
FAMILY	Cervidae
SPECIES	53

Although similar in appearance to antelopes, deer are distinguished by their antlers, which are solid, usually branched, and are shed and regrown each year. Deer are mainly woodland and forest dwellers but can be found in a range of other habitats, from arctic tundra to

grassland. They live in northwest Africa, Eurasia, and the Americas. Some species have also been introduced beyond their natural range; for example, to New Zealand and to Britain and mainland Europe.

Anatomy

Most deer have an elongated body, a long neck, large eyes situated at the side of the head, high-set ears, and a small tail. The well-developed third and fourth digits bear the weight, while the second and fifth toes are smaller and usually do not touch the ground. Each year, the coat is molted at least once. In many species, the young have spots on the coat, for camouflage.

The most striking feature of deer, however, is their antlers, which are present only in males (except in reindeer, where both sexes have them). In spring each year, the antlers begin to develop. They grow directly from the skull and are initially covered by finely haired skin (called velvet). When they have developed, the velvet dries and is rubbed off so that the antlers are ready to be used in fighting during the breeding season (fall). After

breeding (also known as the “rut”), the antlers are shed. It is not certain why antlers are shed and regrown each year, since annual regrowth is metabolically costly—it could be a chance to renew antlers damaged during the rut. Antlers are first grown at 1–2 years of age and are initially simple spikes. As the years progress, the antlers generally become larger and more branched, but regress again in old age. Antler size is an indication of general body condition. Deers that do not have antlers usually have tusklike canines, though the muntjac has both.

Social groups

Social organization depends largely on diet. Smaller species are usually browsers and generally live singly or in small groups. This is because their food occurs in small pockets, which produces competition. Larger species tend to graze more open habitats and therefore compete less for food. These deer often live in herds for protection from predators. Such

MUSK DEER AND CHEVROTAINS

Musk deer (family Moschidae) and chevrotains (family Tragulidae)—also known as mouse deer—have several features that separate them from other deer (family Cervidae). For example, both have long upper canine teeth instead of antlers. In males, these teeth project below the level of the lower jaw and are used for fighting. The 7 species of musk deer (found throughout Asia) are endangered due to demand for musk, which is secreted from the groin of males during the breeding season and is used as an ingredient in many perfumes. Chevrotains (10 species) live in the rain forests of Africa and Asia.

groups are usually single-sex, except during the rut, when males fight for possession of a harem, using their antlers as weapons and sexual ornaments (to attract mates).



SURVIVING HARD TIMES

Those deer that inhabit regions where food becomes scarce during winter browse on a variety of plants to survive. These red deer stags will usually feed for longer periods than hinds, possibly because during the fall rut, they must fight for and defend their harem and can therefore spend less time building fat reserves.